For you and your sister to move out. I don’t allow thieves to rent my rooms or live under my roof. You two are a bad influence on the other women. You both better be gone tomorrow—do you understand?”

There were still two days left in the month and they’d paid the full September rent. She had no right to throw them out before then, nor to steal their personal items. Rose stepped closer and squared her shoulders, ready to fight for her pastels once more.

“Tomorrow morning,” Madame Martin said, “I’ll go to the gendarmerie and report that I found this box of pastels in your room. And unless you can produce the individual who gave them to you, I think you’ll struggle to explain to the officers how you could afford to buy them.” She smiled. “It’s up to you. Explain yourself to the gendarme, or leave the pastels with me, and it will be our little secret.”

Rose felt herself waver.

Madame Martin pressed two fingers to her lips. “I won’t say a word.”

Just a moment ago, Rose had been strong and ready to fight Madame Martin. Now, it felt like someone had hollowed out her insides and tipped all her strength out. She’d been set up, and there was nothing she could do. Léa was right—there was no longer any *fraternité* among people. Everyone was out for themselves.

She pushed past Madame Martin and made her way up the stairs, where Léa stood waiting on the landing, and together they entered their room.

“*Elle est une vraie pute*,” Léa hissed. “I heard it all.”

“She came into our room with the intention of stealing something.” Rose’s eyes filled with tears, her voice wobbling. “But something even worse happened at the cinema.”

Léa stepped closer. “What?”

“The gendarmes were checking identity papers, and when André didn’t have his, they took him away. He’ll be sent to Germany.” The weight of this hit her anew with all its unbearable force and her tears flowed freely. “I’ll never see him again.”

“Oh, Rose, I’m so sorry.” Léa pulled her close and held her.